

FACTS ABOUT THE PURPLE HEART, THE OLDEST MILITARY DECORATION STILL PRESENTED TO US SERVICE MEMBERS

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The Purple Heart is awarded to those wounded or killed in service to the United States. Created by George Washington in 1782, it is the oldest military award still given to American service members. As such, its history is intertwined with stories of bravery and sacrifice. The following are some facts about the medal you might not have known.

ESTABLISHED AS A BADGE OF MILITARY MERIT

The Purple Heart traces its origins back to the American Revolution, when future US President George Washington, who was then the commander-in-chief of the Continental Army, established the Badge of Military Merit. It was made of a simple piece of purple cloth shaped like a heart, symbolizing merit and honor.

Only three soldiers were awarded the Badge of Military Merit: Sgt. Elijah Churchill, Sgt. William Brown and Sgt. Daniel Bissell.

RE-EMERGENCY FOLLOWING THE GREAT WAR

Following the American Revolution, the Badge of Military Merit, while not abolished, wasn't proposed again until after the First World War. An attempt was made by Army Chief of Staff Gen. Charles Pelot Summerall to bring it back, but the motion was, for some reason, withdrawn.

A renewed effort began in 1931. Spearheaded by Gen. Douglas MacArthur, was successful, with the medal re-established the next year, under the "Purple Heart" moniker. Its purpose also changed, with it now able to be presented to soldiers who'd been injured by enemy forces.



Charles Pelot Summerall.

RETROACTIVE TO WORLD WAR 1

Upon the Purple Heart being re-established, the medal was made retroactive to those servicemen who had been injured or lost their lives in World War I. ***The first person to receive it? Douglas MacArthur, who was the Army Chief of Staff at the time.***



Douglas MacArthur.

THE SIGNIFICANCE OF THE PURPLE HEART'S DESIGN



The [design](#) of the Purple Heart, featuring an image of George Washington within a 1 3/8-inch purple and gold heart, reflects its historical roots and the values it represents. The medal's purple hue and heart shape symbolize courage and sacrifice, while the inclusion of Washington's portrait pays homage to the man who created its predecessor.

[HOW MANY WERE PRODUCED FOR THE PROPOSED INVASION OF JAPAN IN WW2 ?](#)

Over the course of the [Second World War](#), 1,506,000 Purple Hearts were manufactured – **500,000 alone for the proposed Allied invasion of the Japanese homelands.** It was anticipated the country would see significant casualties during the engagement, and the military brass wanted to be prepared.

[Japan surrendered](#) before Operation Downfall, as it was known, could be enacted. This meant the military had a surplus of Purple Hearts, which continue to be handed out to this day.

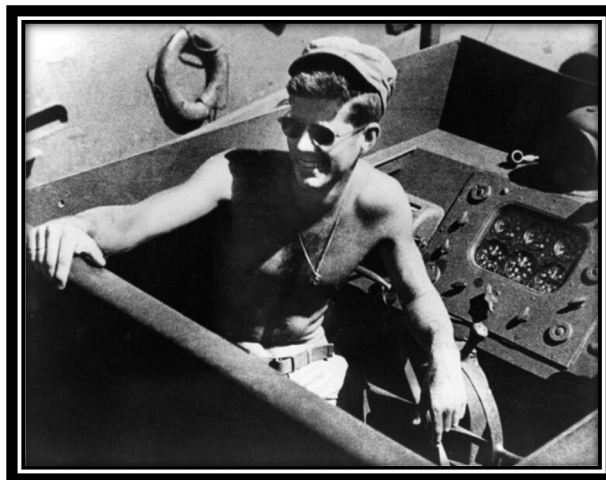
[YOU CAN'T BE RECOMMENDED FOR THE PURPLE HEART](#)



Unlike other decorations handed out by the US military, troops can't be recommended for the Purple Heart. Instead, they automatically receive it once they meet a certain criteria.

To be awarded the Purple Heart, a service member must have been injured as a result of enemy action and received medical attention at the time of the incident. This includes those who tragically lose their lives in the line of duty.

[NOTABLE RECIPIENTS](#)



John F. Kennedy

The Purple Heart has been awarded to [many notable figures](#) throughout its history.

[John F. Kennedy](#) is the only US president to have received the decoration, having been injured while serving in the Second World War, and such actors as [James Garner](#) and [Charles Bronson](#) have also been awarded it.

ANIMALS CAN ALSO RECEIVE THE PURPLE HEART



Sergeant Reckless

Did you know that animals have also been awarded the Purple Heart? Sergeant Stubby, a mutt that served in World War I, was twice the recipient of the decoration, after first becoming injured in a gas attack, then by a grenade blast.

There's also Sergeant Reckless, a horse that served with the US Marine Corps in Korea. She, too, received the Purple Heart twice, for wounds she suffered during the Battle of Outpost Vegas.

THE NATIONAL PURPLE HEART HALL OF HONOR



National Purple Heart Hall of Honor.

The National Purple Heart Hall of Honor, in New Windsor, New York, serves as a tribute to all recipients of the Purple Heart. The **first and only museum** dedicated to a US military medal, it provides a space to honor their sacrifices and educate the public about the medal's significance.



NATIONAL PURPLE HEART DAY

National Purple Heart Day is recognized annually on August 7, in recognition of the date George Washington established the Badge of Military Merit.

NUMBER AWARDED – BY CONFLICT



The number of Purple Hearts (including Military Badges of Merit) that have been awarded over time includes all services and reads like this:

American Revolution – 3
World War I – 320,518
World War II – 1,076,245
Korean War – 118,650

Vietnam War – 351,794

Gulf War – 607

War in Afghanistan – 12,534

Iraq War – 35,411

Operation Inherent Resolve (OIR) – 76

United Nations Multidimensional Integrated Stabilization Mission in Mali – Two



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